



Walls were covered with decorative tapestries or cheaper painted cloth



Straw was used as a mattress

CROWDED HOUSE

William grew up in a crowded house, and probably shared a space-saving "trundle bed" like this with some of his brothers and sisters. In the daytime, the lower bed could be wheeled right under the upper one. In Shakespeare's day, it was normal for children to keep warm by sharing the same bed.

MOTHER'S ROOM

This is thought to be the room where John's wife Mary gave birth to William and his seven brothers and sisters. It has been furnished to show how it may have looked after the birth of William's brother Richard in 1574. A cradle stands by the bed, and the basket is full of strips of linen called swaddling bands used to wrap babies.



Knobs and grooves carved by hand on a lathe



BUILT TO IMPRESS

As a small child, William probably sat in a high chair just like this. The elaborate decoration would have made it an expensive item of furniture. The carving was not for the baby's benefit, but to impress neighbors and visitors. Parents who could afford such a fancy high chair would have given an impression of wealth and good taste.

FAMILY MISFORTUNES

For a time, John Shakespeare's businesses were very successful, and he could afford expensive tableware, like these pewter dishes in the hall of the Birthplace Museum. In 1576, however, John's businesses began to fail. He got into debt and lost his position of importance in the town. William, who was 12 years old at the time, must have been affected by his father's money problems. When he grew up, he would work to restore his family's fortunes.